out every detail, including the organisation of cultural life. We also had a list of anti-Hitler people we assumed to be in Berlin, with names of communist and social democratic members of the Reichstag and other opponents of Hitler from bourgeois groups. So, we arrived in Germany on 30 April 1945 well prepared. We reached Berlin on 1 May, and then our work began.

4

What endeared the Russians to Ulbricht was his neurotic allegiance to Stalin. He was adept at creating controversy. Any failures or misjudgements by the Soviets were rarely discussed as, time after time, he stubbornly supported Russia on a multitude of issues. For example, when there were complaints that German factories were being dismantled and shipped to the Soviet Union – increasing the suffering of the local population – he backed Moscow. From the moment the Red Army rolled into Berlin, military units had set about dismantling AEG, Borsig, Osram, Siemens and hundreds of other industrial concerns.

Another thorny issue concerned his point-blank refusal to entertain discussion on the rape of German women by Russian soldiers, an outrage which also compromised the Soviet claim to be a liberator. Devoid of emotional intelligence, Ulbricht remained unmoved by calls from victims to have abortions, dismaying many in his own ranks. Moreover, his faithfulness to his Soviet mentors knew no bounds, even before the war, he wrote in defence of Stalin's despised 1939 non-aggression pact with the Nazis.

For his part, Honecker remembered Ulbricht as an earthy, thick-set fellow with thinning hair, wire-rimmed glasses, goatee beard and a high-pitched voice. He could be brusque and was not a man people relaxed around. 'Walter Ulbricht, whom I did not know until then, went from table to table,' he recounted of their first meeting. 'He also came to the table where I sat with some comrades and asked about our past, insofar as he did not know